

The Road to the Civil War

Follow the chain of conflicts over slavery's expansion from 1850 to 1861 and decide which link did the most to make war unavoidable.

? Historical challenge

The Civil War did not begin with a single event. Through the 1850s, a chain of conflicts over whether slavery could expand into the western territories pushed the nation toward war — each action producing a sharper reaction. Trace the chain from pressure to consequence, and decide which link mattered most.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Dred Scott v. Sandford (1857) — National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The Supreme Court judgment that denied Black citizenship and struck down the Missouri Compromise.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the Court decide about citizenship and about Congress's power?
- How might Northerners and Southerners react differently to this ruling?

SOURCES 2

Bleeding Kansas — National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How popular sovereignty turned Kansas into a battleground over slavery.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did violence break out in Kansas?
- How did this deepen the conflict between North and South?

SOURCES 3

Trigger Events of the Civil War — American Battlefield Trust

SECONDARY SOURCE

The escalating chain of events from the Fugitive Slave Act to Fort Sumter.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Which events form the chain toward war?
- Which one seems to be the point of no return?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

PRESSURE



ACTION



REACTION



ESCALATION



EVENT



CONSEQUENCES

Where might events have gone differently?

People / groups responsible

Stephen A. Douglas — authored the Kansas–Nebraska Act and popular sovereignty

Chief Justice Roger B. Taney — wrote the Dred Scott majority opinion

John Brown — led the Harpers Ferry raid

Which link was most important?

	Abraham Lincoln — whose election triggered secession	
Sources 1	Sources 2	Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your chains with a partner. Did you order the links the same way?
- Did you choose the same 'most important link'? Defend your choice with evidence.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Which link in the chain did the most to make war unavoidable? Support your claim with evidence from at least two sources and two links.